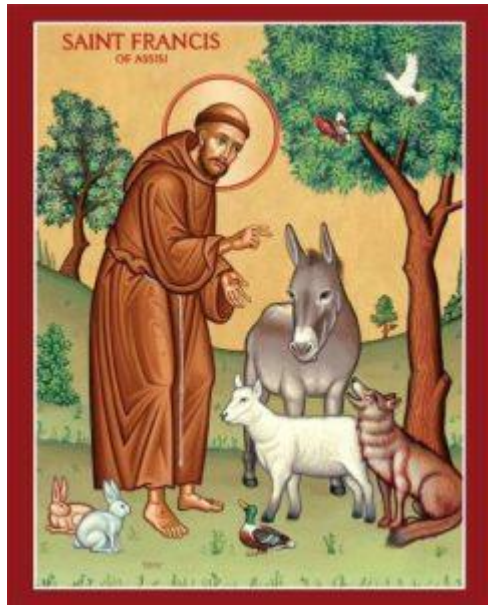
- **One common misattribution.** "Preach the Gospel at all times. When necessary, use words" is a modern aphorism found neither in his writings nor in the early biographies.
- **The fuller booklet.** A longer print edition, with the introduction, the biographical timeline, and a table of contents, is at prayers-of-st-francis-of-assisi.md — the booklet this pamphlet was trimmed from.
- **The full study** — his life, conversion, the rule, the stigmata at La Verna, the canonization, and the Franciscan family — is in saints/st-francis-assisi.md.

Prayers of St. Francis of Assisi



St. Francis in Brief

St. Francis of Assisi (1181/1182 – 3 October 1226) left very little writing, and what he left is almost entirely prayer. The eight prayers in this pamphlet are drawn from that small body of work. Each is introduced by its manuscript or occasion, and the two that are later devotional compositions are marked as such — a distinction worth keeping, because the best-known prayer under his name is not his. The Church commemorates him on **4 October**.

1. The Prayer Before the Crucifix (San Damiano, c. 1205–1206)

Prayed before the painted crucifix in the ruined chapel of San Damiano, from which he heard the call to repair God's house. It is the earliest datable text from his hand.

```
Most High and glorious God,
enlighten the darkness of my heart,
and give me right faith,
certain hope,
and perfect charity,
with insight and knowledge, Lord,
that I may carry out
your holy and true command.
Amen.
```

2. The Praises of God Most High (La Verna, 1224)

Written on a small parchment at La Verna and given to Brother Leo; the parchment, in Francis's own hand, is still preserved at Assisi. Not petition but pure praise.

```
You are holy, Lord, the only God,
and your deeds are wonderful.
You are strong. You are great. You are the Most High.
You are almighty. You, holy Father, King of heaven and earth.
You are three and one, Lord God, all good.
```

8. The "Peace Prayer" — Commonly Attributed to St. Francis

Not his. "Lord, make me an instrument of your peace" was first published anonymously in 1912 in the French Franciscan bulletin *La Clochette*, and was attributed to Francis only from about 1916. Pope John Paul II, praying it at Assisi in 1986, introduced it as a prayer "commonly attributed to Saint Francis." It is printed here because it is widely loved and often wanted for prayer, but it should not be quoted as his own words.

```
Lord, make me an instrument of your peace.
Where there is hatred, let me sow love;
where there is injury, pardon;
where there is doubt, faith;
where there is despair, hope;
where there is darkness, light;
and where there is sadness, joy.

O Divine Master, grant that I may not so much seek
to be consoled as to console,
to be understood as to understand,
to be loved as to love.
For it is in giving that we receive,
it is in pardoning that we are forgiven,
and it is in dying that we are born to eternal life.

Amen.
```

A Note on These Texts

- **Sources.** Sections 1–3 and 5 are Francis's own, preserved in the critical collection of his *Opuscula* and translated in *Francis of Assisi: Early Documents*, vol. 1. Section 4 is his *Cantico delle Creature*. Section 6 is the Collect of the Roman Missal. Sections 7 and 8 are later devotional compositions.
- **Wording varies.** English renderings of Francis's prayers and of the Italian Collect differ between translations; none of the renderings here is normative or official except the Italian of the Collect.

```
Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son,
who is God, and lives and reigns with you,
in the unity of the Holy Spirit,
one God, for ever and ever.

Amen.
```

7. A Prayer Asking His Intercession

A devotional composition inspired by the Franciscan tradition — not a text written by the saint — asking for simplicity, peace, love of creation, and the courage to live the Gospel without compromise.

```
O seraphic St. Francis, mirror of Christ's poverty
and herald of the Great King,
you who were so conformed to Jesus crucified
that you bore His sacred wounds in your own flesh,
obtain for us a heart detached from worldly goods
and burning with love for God alone.

St. Francis, lover of all God's creatures,
teach us to see the Creator's beauty in every living thing;
St. Francis, instrument of Christ's peace,
make us channels of that peace
where there is hatred, injury, doubt, and despair.

St. Francis of Assisi, little poor man of God,
pray for us now and at the hour of our death.

Amen.
```

A shorter invocation for daily use:

```
St. Francis of Assisi,
pray for us.
```

```
You are good, all good, supreme good,
Lord God, living and true.
You are love. You are wisdom.
You are humility. You are endurance.
You are rest. You are peace.
You are joy and gladness.
You are justice and moderation.
You are all our riches, and you suffice for us.
You are beauty. You are gentleness.
You are our protector. You are our guardian and defender.
You are courage. You are our haven and our hope.
You are our faith, our great consolation.
You are our eternal life, great and wonderful Lord,
God almighty, merciful Savior.
```

3. The "Absorbeat" — A Prayer to Obtain Love

A brief prayer asking for the charity that consumed him; its opening word, *Absorbeat*, supplies its customary name.

```
Lord, I beg you,
let the sweet and burning power of your love
absorb my mind,
that I may die for love of your love,
you who deigned to die
for love of my love.
```

4. The Canticle of Brother Sun (1225)

Composed in grave illness and near-blindness, the *Cantico delle Creature* is the earliest great poem of the Italian vernacular. His companions read its final verse, welcoming "Sister Death," to him at the last. Translators differ considerably; no single English version is normative.

```
Most High, all-powerful, good Lord,
yours are the praises, the glory, the honour, and all blessing.
To you alone, Most High, do they belong,
```

```
and no one is worthy to speak your name.

Praised be you, my Lord, with all your creatures,
especially Sir Brother Sun,
who is the day, and through whom you give us light.
He is beautiful and radiant with great splendour,
and bears a likeness of you, Most High One.

Praised be you, my Lord, through Sister Moon and the stars:
in heaven you formed them clear and precious and beautiful.

Praised be you, my Lord, through Brother Wind,
and through the air, cloudy and serene, and every kind of weather,
through which you give sustenance to your creatures.

Praised be you, my Lord, through Sister Water,
who is very useful and humble and precious and chaste.

Praised be you, my Lord, through Brother Fire,
through whom you light the night;
he is beautiful and playful and robust and strong.

Praised be you, my Lord, through our Sister Mother Earth,
who sustains and governs us,
and produces various fruits with coloured flowers and herbs.

Praised be you, my Lord, through those who give pardon for your
love,
and bear infirmity and tribulation.
Blessed are those who endure in peace,
for by you, Most High, they shall be crowned.

Praised be you, my Lord, through our Sister Bodily Death,
from whom no living being can escape.
Woe to those who die in mortal sin;
blessed are those whom death finds in your most holy will,
for the second death shall do them no harm.

Praise and bless my Lord, and give him thanks,
and serve him with great humility.
```

5. The Blessing of Brother Leo

On the reverse of the La Verna parchment Francis wrote out the priestly blessing of Numbers 6:24–26, signing it with the *tau*. It may be prayed over anyone in need of it.

```
The Lord bless you and keep you.
The Lord make his face shine upon you, and be gracious to you.
The Lord lift up his countenance upon you,
and give you peace.

Amen.
```

6. The Collect of His Feast (4 October)

The Church's own prayer asking his intercession, from the Roman Missal. His celebration is a **Memorial** in the General Roman Calendar and a **Feast** in Italy, where Pope Pius XII proclaimed him patron on 18 June 1939.

```
O Padre, che hai concesso a san Francesco
di essere immagine viva di Cristo povero e umile,
fa' che, camminando sulle sue orme,
possiamo seguire il tuo Figlio
e unirci a te in carità e letizia.
Per il nostro Signore Gesù Cristo, tuo Figlio, che è Dio,
e vive e regna con te, nell'unità dello Spirito Santo,
per tutti i secoli dei secoli.

Amen.
```

A working English rendering (the approved English wording varies by translation):

```
Father, you granted Saint Francis
to be a living image of Christ, poor and humble;
grant that, walking in his footsteps,
we may follow your Son
and be united to you in charity and joy.
```